Executive Brief: Why It Takes So Long to Fill Our Open Positions

Based on HR system exports as of 31 Oct 2026 | 271 completed hires, Feb 2024 to Oct 2026

Principal conclusion:

Right now, only about one in three new hires is fully onboarded within 90 days of the job first being posted. The biggest thing slowing us down is something we can control: how many selection rounds we add before interviews. When a hiring manager uses both a phone screen and a technical assessment, we almost never make the 90-day goal.

What the data shows:

1. Most hires miss the goal. Of the 271 people hired, 99 (36.5%) finished onboarding within 90 days. A typical hire took 95 days.

2. Extra selection rounds make the biggest difference. When there were no optional rounds, 57% of hires (59 of 104) made it within 90 days. When both a phone screen and a technical assessment were used, only 2 out of 40 did (5%). Using just one of the two landed in between: 35% with a phone screen only and 26% with a technical assessment only.

3. Two hiring-manager steps run the most over their targets. Reviewing résumés takes about 9 days instead of the planned 7, and putting together the interview panel takes about 7 days instead of 5. Neither delay is large on its own, but every step waits for the one before it, so a couple of extra days here and there quickly adds up.

What I recommend:

Treat extra selection rounds as the exception rather than the norm. By default, a hiring manager would choose one optional round, either a phone screen or a technical assessment, and would need HR's approval to use both. Hiring managers should also start lining up their interview panel while they're shortlisting candidates, not after. I'd suggest trying this in one administration for two quarters and comparing the results with today's 36.5%.

A caveat to keep in mind:

This tells us the two things go together, but it doesn't prove that one causes the other. Harder or more senior roles might naturally use more selection rounds and take longer for other reasons. The source data also needed cleanup: there were inconsistent spellings, duplicate rows and a few impossible dates, all of which I documented. Jobs that are still open or were cancelled aren't included in the 36.5%. That's why a small pilot is the right next step before changing the process across the agency.